

More on the special composition question

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Van Inwagen's Proposed Answer to the Special Composition Question

The xs compose something iff the activity of the xs constitutes a life, or there is only one of the xs.

- What is a life? A certain kind of self-maintaining event that is 'reasonably well-individuated' and 'jealous' (it never happens that the activity of the same things constitutes two different lives).

- A consequence of this view: there are no tables or computers or statues or lumps of clay or ships or grains of sand.... For surely if there was such a things as a table, etc., it would have to be composed by some things whose activity did not constitute a life (and which were more than one in number).
- NB: when you're describing this aspect of van Inwagen's views, pay attention to the paragraph on pp. 99-100.

Is this consistent with ordinary belief?

- The analogy with ‘the sun went behind the elms’.
- The bliger case

- Distinguish several different questions:
 - Do most people believe that there are chairs?
 - Do most people have *good reason* to believe that there are chairs?
 - When ordinary people utter sentences like ‘there are two very valuable chairs in the next room’, do they thereby express a proposition that could not be true unless there were chairs?
 - Would there have to be chairs for *sentences* like ‘there are two very valuable chairs in the next room’ to be true?

- Rosen and Dorr seem to regard it as obvious that van Inwagen is wrong about this.
- If we think he is wrong, we still face the question whether the fact that certain opinions about composition are commonly held by non-philosophers gives *us* any *reason* to accept those opinions.
 - Could these opinions be mere prejudices?

Two models for a defence of common sense about composition

- Consider a typical *sceptical hypothesis*: e.g. the hypothesis that you are hooked up to a giant Matrix-like simulation. Presumably it's reasonable for you to believe that this is false. Why?
- One line of thought about this question say that it's because we *find it so natural* to believe it, or because we *already* believe it.

- Suppose that this is a good account of how we get to be justified in rejecting outlandish sceptical hypotheses. Could we have justification of a similar sort for rejecting Universalism, Nihilism, etc.?
- A fact Rosen and Dorr think is relevant here: when common sense says ‘surely there are chairs’, it does so without even *considering* the sorts of alternative hypotheses that Universalists, Nihilists, etc. believe. These hypotheses never cross our minds.

- A second model: consider a bizarre sceptic about shape, who holds that all three-sided figures are pentagons, and all five-sided figures are triangles.
 - How do we argue against this sceptic?
 - One move: ‘Look, you agree that people generally *apply* the term “triangle” to three-sided figures and “pentagon” to five-sided ones. Wouldn’t it be more charitable to interpret them as speaking the truth, when they do this? And doesn’t this give us reason to think that this charitable interpretation is correct?’

- One could try making a similar move in the case of common sense claims about composition:
‘Look, ordinary people who see a bunch of blocks arranged in the form of a house will *say* “these blocks compose a house”. Shouldn’t we interpret them, charitably, as saying something that’s literally true when they say that?’
 - But what is this charitable interpretation? It’s not as if the Nihilist or Organicist is capriciously refusing to apply the predicate ‘house’ to certain objects that ordinary people classify as ‘houses’: the Nihilists and Organicists think that *there isn’t anything there to classify*.

- The same goes for terms like ‘object’, ‘entity’, etc.
 - Also ‘part’ and ‘compose’. It’s not that there are these things, of which common sense says that they have certain atoms as parts, such that van Inwagen denies that they have those atoms as parts.
- If we want to accuse the opponent of “common sense” of being unduly uncharitable in his interpretation of some ordinary expressions, these expressions will have to include the *quantifiers*: words like ‘something’ in ‘these atoms compose something’.
 - But don’t we already know the meanings of these words? What alternatives are there to our actual meanings?

Unity, thinking and Nihilism

- Question 1: How strong is the support for each of the premises in the following argument against Nihilism?
 1. I exist.
 2. If I exist, I am a composite thing.
 3. Therefore, there is at least one composite thing.
- Question 2: Does it make sense to suppose that some things might *jointly* think, believe, feel, etc., without composing anything?